

VEGANISM - LIVE DEBATE MASTER SHEET

FACT FIRST • SIMPLE LANGUAGE • SOURCE DIRECTLY UNDER EACH CLAIM



WHAT IS VEGANISM? A philosophy and way of living that seeks to exclude animal exploitation and cruelty as far as possible and practicable. It is bigger than a diet: it also concerns clothing, testing, entertainment and other uses of animals.

EXPLOITATION = using an animal as a resource or for someone else's benefit.

SOURCE: The Vegan Society - formal definition <https://www.vegansociety.com/go-vegan/definition-veganism>

1. NUTRITION / HEALTH

Adequacy: Appropriately planned vegan diets can be nutritionally adequate for adults and support long-term cardiometabolic health.

SOURCE: Academy of Nutrition and Dietetics position (2025)

<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jand.2025.02.002>

Protein: Plant foods contain all essential amino acids. Meeting total protein and calorie needs matters more than combining proteins at every meal.

SOURCE: Mariotti & Gardner, Nutrients (2019)

<https://doi.org/10.3390/nu11112661>

RCT evidence: An 8-week randomized identical-twin trial found lower LDL cholesterol, body weight and fasting insulin in the vegan group.

SOURCE: Landry et al., JAMA Network Open (2023)

<https://doi.org/10.1001/jamanetworkopen.2023.44457>

2. B12 / COMMON NUTRIENTS

B12: Vegans need a reliable B12 source from fortified foods or supplements.

Needing B12 supplementation does not make a diet invalid; it makes B12 a nutrient that must be supplied.

SOURCE: NIH Office of Dietary Supplements

<https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/VitaminB12-HealthProfessional/>

Iron / calcium / omega-3: These nutrients exist in plant foods; adequacy depends on food choice, fortification and, when appropriate, supplements - just as nutrient adequacy matters in any diet.

SOURCE: Melina et al., J Acad Nutr Diet (2016)

<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jand.2016.09.025>

3. PLANTS / SENTIENCE

"Plants feel pain": Plants sense and react to their environment, but current evidence does not show that plants consciously experience pain. They do not have animal-like brains or nervous systems.

SOURCE: Taiz et al., Trends in Plant Science (2020)

<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tplants.2020.05.005>

Sentience is not intelligence: The ethical issue is whether a being can have subjective experiences such as pain or distress - not whether it can solve human-style problems.

SOURCE: Birch et al., LSE sentience review (2021)

<https://www.lse.ac.uk/business/consulting/assets/documents/invertebrate-sentience.pdf>

4. "ANIMALS EAT ANIMALS" / OMNIVORES

Animals eat animals: What wild animals do tells us what happens in nature; it does not tell humans what is morally justified when we can choose alternatives.

SOURCE: Logic: appeal-to-nature distinction

<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/moral-animal/>

"Humans are omnivores": Being able to eat animal foods does not prove that animal foods are nutritionally required. Ability is not necessity.

SOURCE: Academy of Nutrition and Dietetics (2025)

<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jand.2025.02.002>

5. CROPS / CROP DEATHS

Crop deaths: Crop farming can harm animals. Veganism does not claim zero harm. The relevant question is which food system uses fewer resources and causes less avoidable animal use overall.

SOURCE: Poore & Nemecek, Science (2018)

<https://doi.org/10.1126/science.aag0216>

Feed conversion: Feeding human-edible crops to animals and then eating the animals loses food calories compared with direct human consumption.

SOURCE: Cassidy et al., Environmental Research Letters (2013)

<https://doi.org/10.1088/1748-9326/8/3/034015>

6. SOY - GET THE NUMBERS RIGHT

Global soy use: About 77% of global soy is used for livestock feed. Only about 7% is used directly for foods such as tofu, soy milk, tempeh and edamame. The remaining share includes soybean oil plus smaller biofuel/industrial uses - not 60% industrial use.

SOURCE: Our World in Data synthesis of FCRN/USDA data

<https://ourworldindata.org/drivers-of-deforestation>

Deforestation context: In the Brazilian Amazon, pasture expansion for beef has been a much larger direct driver of deforestation than soy for human foods.

SOURCE: Tyukavina et al., Science Advances (2017)

<https://doi.org/10.1126/sciadv.1601047>

7. ENVIRONMENT / LAND

Land use: Meat and dairy use most agricultural land while supplying a minority of global calories and protein. A no-animal-product scenario greatly reduces agricultural land demand.

SOURCE: Poore & Nemecek, Science (2018)

<https://doi.org/10.1126/science.aag0216>

Real-world diets: A large UK analysis found vegan diets had substantially lower greenhouse-gas emissions, land use, water use, eutrophication and biodiversity impacts than high-meat diets.

SOURCE: Scarborough et al., Nature Food (2023)

<https://doi.org/10.1038/s43016-023-00795-w>

8. "HUMANE" / LOCAL / FREE-RANGE

Welfare vs rights: Better conditions can reduce some suffering, but "humane,"

"local" or "free-range" does not answer the separate question: was breeding, using or killing the animal necessary?

SOURCE: Ethical distinction; welfare evidence reviewed by EFSA

<https://www.efsa.europa.eu/en/topics/topic/animal-welfare>

Transport: Scientific welfare assessments identify heat stress, thirst, fatigue, pain, fear and distress as transport hazards for farmed animals.

SOURCE: EFSA Journal - animal transport opinions

<https://www.efsa.europa.eu/en/topics/topic/animal-welfare>

9. DAIRY / EGGS / SLAUGHTER

Dairy: Milk production requires reproduction. Dairy systems produce calves, separate many calves from dams, and cows eventually leave production and are commonly slaughtered.

SOURCE: Meagher et al., Applied Animal Behaviour Science (2019)

<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.applanim.2018.11.011>

Eggs: Egg production is an animal-use system involving breeding and eventual culling/slaughter; welfare problems can include bone damage, injurious pecking and confinement depending on system.

SOURCE: Lay et al., Poultry Science (2011)

<https://doi.org/10.3382/ps.2010-00962>

10. FISH / AQUATIC ANIMALS

Fish pain: Reviews find evidence consistent with pain perception in fish, including nociception, learning and behavioral changes after harmful stimulation.

SOURCE: Sneddon et al., Philosophical Transactions B (2014)

<https://doi.org/10.1098/rstb.2013.0086>

Scale: Estimated numbers of farmed finfish killed for food are in the tens to hundreds of billions annually; wild-caught finfish estimates are far larger.

SOURCE: Mood et al., Animal Welfare (2024)

<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/38487450/>

11. DOGS / CATS

Dogs: A 12-month prospective study found dogs maintained clinical, hematological and nutritional health on a complete commercial plant-based diet.

SOURCE: Knight et al. (2024)

<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/38625934/>

Cats: A study of 1,369 cats found no statistically significant overall health disadvantage for cats fed vegan diets; formulation and nutrient adequacy remain essential.

SOURCE: Knight et al., PLOS ONE (2023)

<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/37703240/>

12. COST / AFFORDABILITY

Food cost: In a U.S. randomized trial, a low-fat vegan diet reduced total food costs by about 16% compared with participants' baseline diets.

SOURCE: Kahleova et al., JAMA Network Open (2023)

<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/37669055/>

Simple reality: A vegan diet does not require specialty substitutes: beans, lentils, rice, oats, pasta, potatoes and seasonal/frozen produce can form the inexpensive base.

SOURCE: Study above + basic commodity foods

<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/37669055/>

13. PUBLIC HEALTH

Antimicrobial resistance: Antimicrobial use in food animals can select for resistant organisms; reducing unnecessary antimicrobial use is a major One Health goal.

SOURCE: Tang et al., Lancet Planetary Health (2017)

[https://doi.org/10.1016/S2542-5196\(17\)30141-9](https://doi.org/10.1016/S2542-5196(17)30141-9)

Zoonotic disease: Many emerging infectious diseases are zoonotic. Land-use change, wildlife contact and livestock systems can influence spillover risk.

SOURCE: Jones et al., Nature (2008)

<https://doi.org/10.1038/nature06536>

14. ONE PERSON / PERSONAL CHOICE

"One person does not matter": Markets respond to combined demand. No single purchase has to cause one animal death for purchases collectively to influence production.

SOURCE: Consumer ethics / expected-demand argument

<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/vegetarianism/>

"Personal choice": A choice stops being only personal when it deliberately uses another sentient being. The disagreement is about whose interests count.

SOURCE: Ethical argument - not a scientific claim

<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/moral-animal/>

15. FARMERS / TRANSITION

Farmers: A pro-vegan transition should include farmers, workers and rural communities. Moving away from animal agriculture does not mean abandoning farmers; it means changing what is produced and supporting the transition.

SOURCE: Practical examples: Transfarmation + Rowdy Girl Rancher Advocacy

<https://transfarmationproject.org/> | <https://rowdygirlsanctuary.org/>

Remember: Farmer-transition programs are practical examples, not peer-reviewed scientific evidence. Use them when someone asks, "What happens to farmers?"

SOURCE: Source type clearly labeled

<https://transfarmationproject.org/>

GO VEGAN - Facts. Evidence. Compassion.

Learn more, explore the evidence & get resources:

michaelsboost.com/govegan/